



Forgotten Software: LibreOffice and Mail Merge

Old software doesn't die! In this article, let's see how mail merge can assist us in carrying out tedious, routine tasks very smoothly and efficiently, and without much effort.

Imagine a scenario in which you need to send reminders to members of your housing society to pay their dues. The data you need is in a spreadsheet. The number of people is large and creating a custom document for each is tedious. It seems like overkill to write a Python program, apart from which, the program may need to be modified if there are changes in the spreadsheet.

That is when it struck me that we used to rely on mail merge tools with Office suites to create personalised letters and labels to mail them! Needless to say, the functionality is alive and well in LibreOffice as well.

You will need to make sure that the LibreOffice Base package is installed as it may not be included by default in the LibreOffice installation.

A simple example

For the sake of simplicity, you just need the 'Flat number' and the 'Amount due' as the data for the letter. So, your spreadsheet needs just two columns. Save it as *SocietyDues.ods*.

Flat number	Amount due	Email
101	500	101@example.com
102	700	102@example.com

The next step is to create a skeleton document. A basic example is shown below:

Attention Flat owner of
Please pay the amount as soon as possible.

You will need to specify the source of the data for merging with this document. Under 'Edit', you will find the 'Exchange Database...' option. Select the spreadsheet and the sheet within it. Click 'Define' to associate the sheet for the data to be used in the document.

Under 'Tools', use the 'Mail merge wizard' to get the toolbar for mail merge options. You can view the spreadsheet and graphically drag the 'Flat number' and 'Amount due' columns to the location that the data should appear in the document.

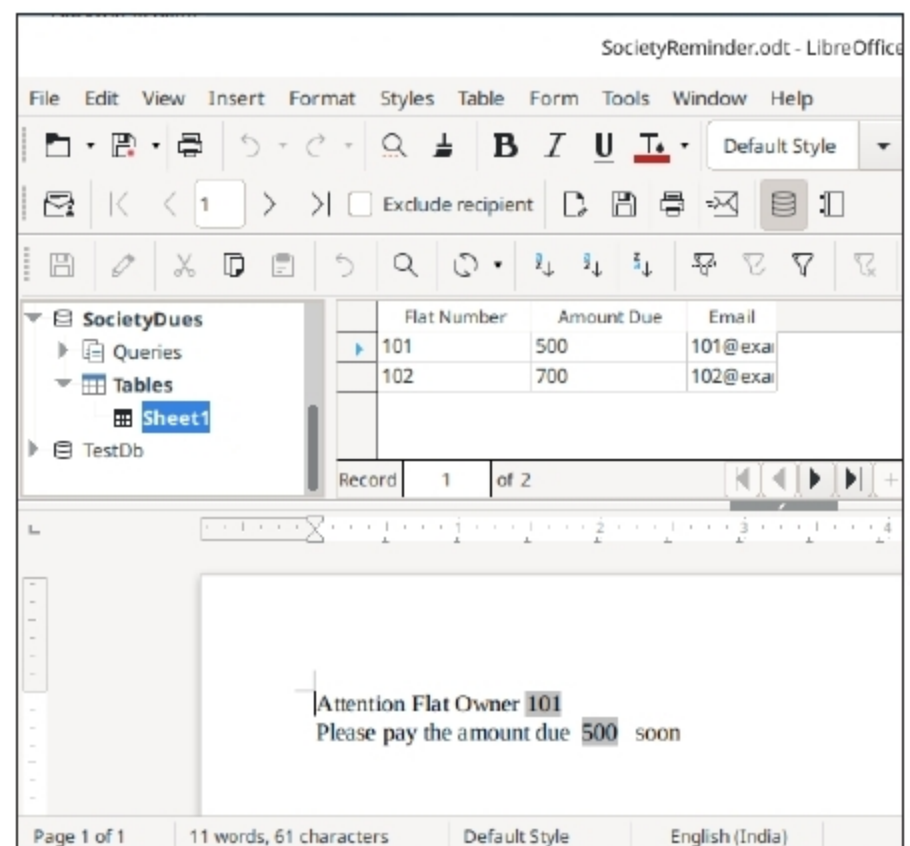


Figure 1: A screenshot with the mail merge toolbar

The document will now look like what's shown in Figure 1.

Attention Flat owner of <Flat Number>
Please pay the amount <Amount Due> as soon as possible.

The mail merge toolbar allows you to view the merged document. You have the option to save the merged document or print it.

There is also the option to mail the documents using the email addresses. Google Docs also has these options using extensions.

So, as you can see, old software does not die! It would not surprise me if a version soon offers the option to send the documents using WhatsApp or a similar messaging tool. **END** 🐧

By: Dr Anil Seth

The author has earned the right to do what interests him. You can find him online at <http://sethanil.com> and <http://sethanil.blogspot.com>.